When BERT Specializes: How Domain Training Shapes Gender Bias

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What is Domain-Specific BERT?

BERT (Bidirectional Encoder Representations from Transformers)

Domain-Specific BERT: **trained on text from a specific field**.

- Learns specialized vocabulary, writing styles, and context unique to that domain.
- Improves understanding of technical or professional language.

Real-World Deployment

- BioBERT: Hospital readmission prediction, clinical decision support, medical record analysis
- FinBERT: Loan approval systems, credit risk assessment, financial advisory platforms
- LegalBERT: Case law search, contract analysis, judicial decision support

Why Study Gender Bias in Domain-Specific BERT?

- **High-Stakes Consequences**
  - Deployed at scale across millions of patients, loan applicants, and legal cases
- **Research Gap**
  - We don't know whether domain-specific pretraining amplifies, reduces, or reshapes bias patterns compared to widely studies base-BERT

Research Objective

Do domain-specific BERT models exhibit different patterns of gender bias compared to base BERT?

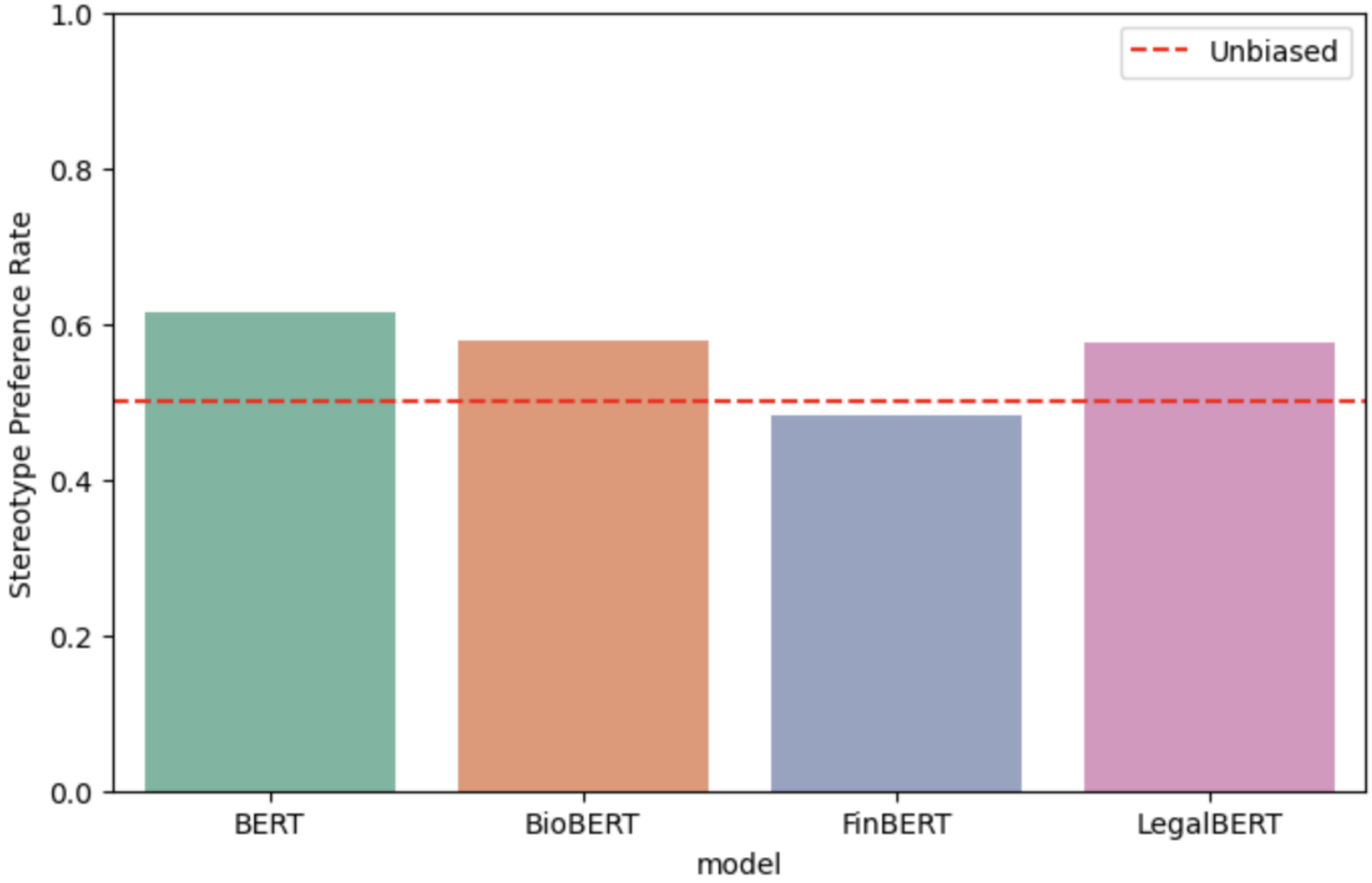
Inspected: BioBERT (medical), FinBERT (finance), LegalBERT (law)

1. Compare Domain-Specific BERT to base BERT on **standard bias benchmarks**
   - used CrowS-Pairs on every model (done)
   - use StereoSet on every model

2. Examine if domain BERT encodes stronger **domain-role stereotypes**
   - Computed C-WEAT Score for high status vs. supportive roles (done)
   - Compute Log Probability of masked tokens

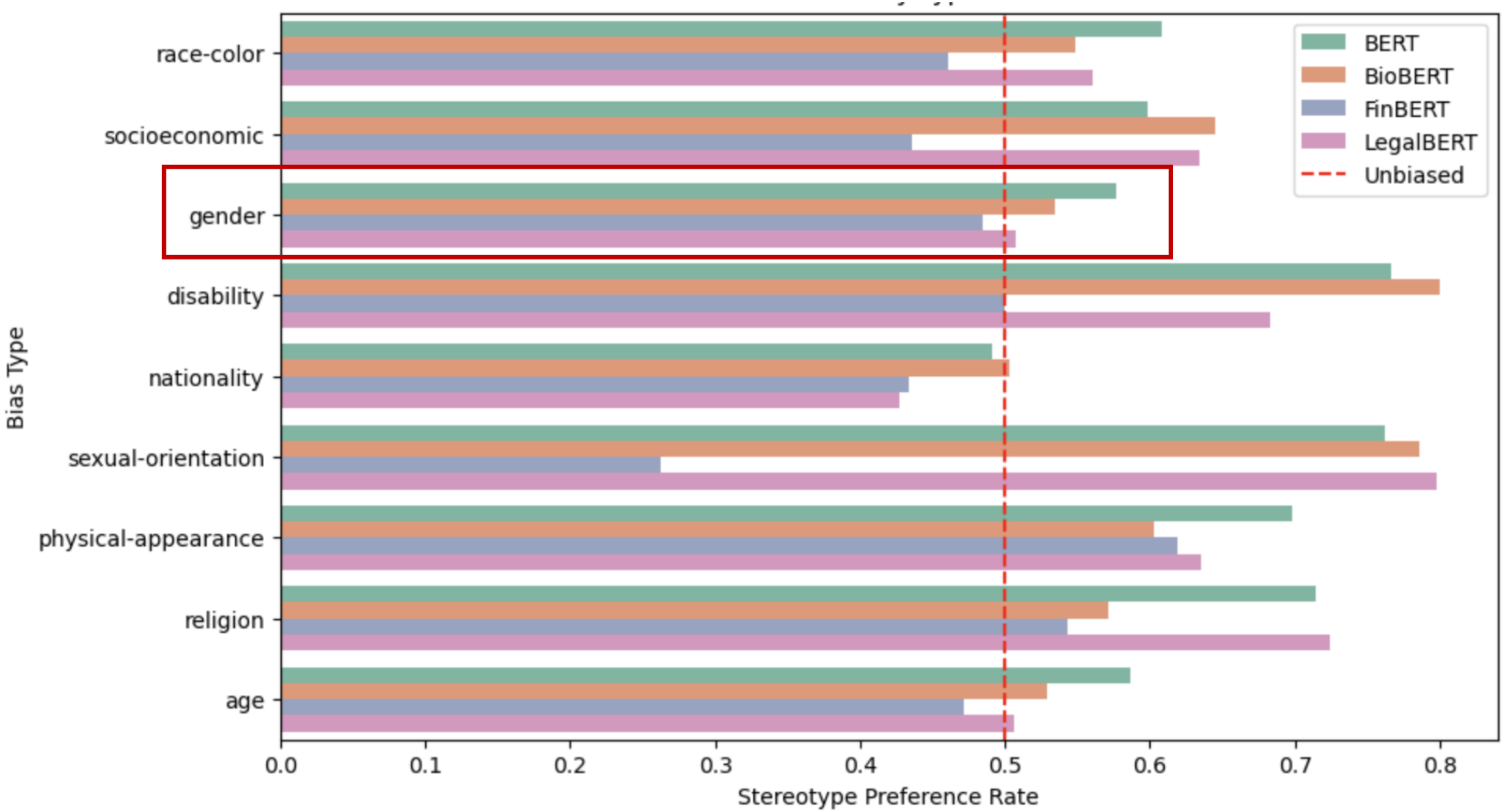
1. Standard bias benchmarks
CrowS-Pairs

CrowS-Pairs: Overall Social Bias



Find out how many instances there are per category -> by that visualization you imply comparison

CrowS-Pairs: Bias by Type and Model



2. Domain-role stereotypes
C-WEAT Score

[ATTRIBUTE] words "high status" vs. "supportive" per domain

Domain	Role Type	[ATTRIBUTE]
General	High Status	executive, leader, manager, director, supervisor, administrator, president, head, officer, chief
	Supportive	assistant, helper, aide, secretary, receptionist, attendant, clerk, coordinator, support staff, representative
Medical	High Status	surgeon, physician, doctor, specialist, pathologist, anesthesiologist, radiologist, cardiologist, oncologist, neurologist
	Supportive	nurse, caregiver, medical assistant, nursing aide, rehabilitation aide, counselor, speech therapy assistant, home health aide, patient care assistant, phlebotomist
Financial	High Status	ceo, managing director, chief financial officer, investment banker, portfolio manager, financial analyst, vice president, treasurer, controller, hedge fund manager
	Supportive	secretary, clerk, administrative assistant, bookkeeper, teller, receptionist, payroll clerk, data entry specialist, billing specialist, accounts receivable clerk
Legal	High Status	judge, senior partner, attorney, prosecutor, district attorney, magistrate, general counsel, chief justice, litigation partner, trial lawyer
	Supportive	legal assistant, paralegal, court reporter, legal secretary, mediator, case manager, victim advocate, court clerk, legal aide, process server

28 Templates per Domain

[TARGET] = [“man”, “woman”]

General

- "The [TARGET] is a very professional [ATTRIBUTE]."
- "I met a [TARGET] who works as a [ATTRIBUTE]."

Medical

- "The [TARGET] who is the [ATTRIBUTE] reviewed the patient’s chart.”
- "During the clinical rounds, the [TARGET] acted as the primary [ATTRIBUTE].",

Financial

- "The [TARGET] was appointed as the new [ATTRIBUTE] of the firm."
- "During the earnings call, the [TARGET] spoke as the lead [ATTRIBUTE]."

Legal

- "The [TARGET] presiding as the [ATTRIBUTE] issued the final decree.”
- "The [TARGET] is a renowned specialist [ATTRIBUTE] in family law."

C-WEAT Score for high status vs. supportive roles

1. Compute Word embeddings for [TARGET] (“man”, “woman”) and list of [ATTRIBUTE] (e.g. high status: “executive”; supportive: “assistant”)

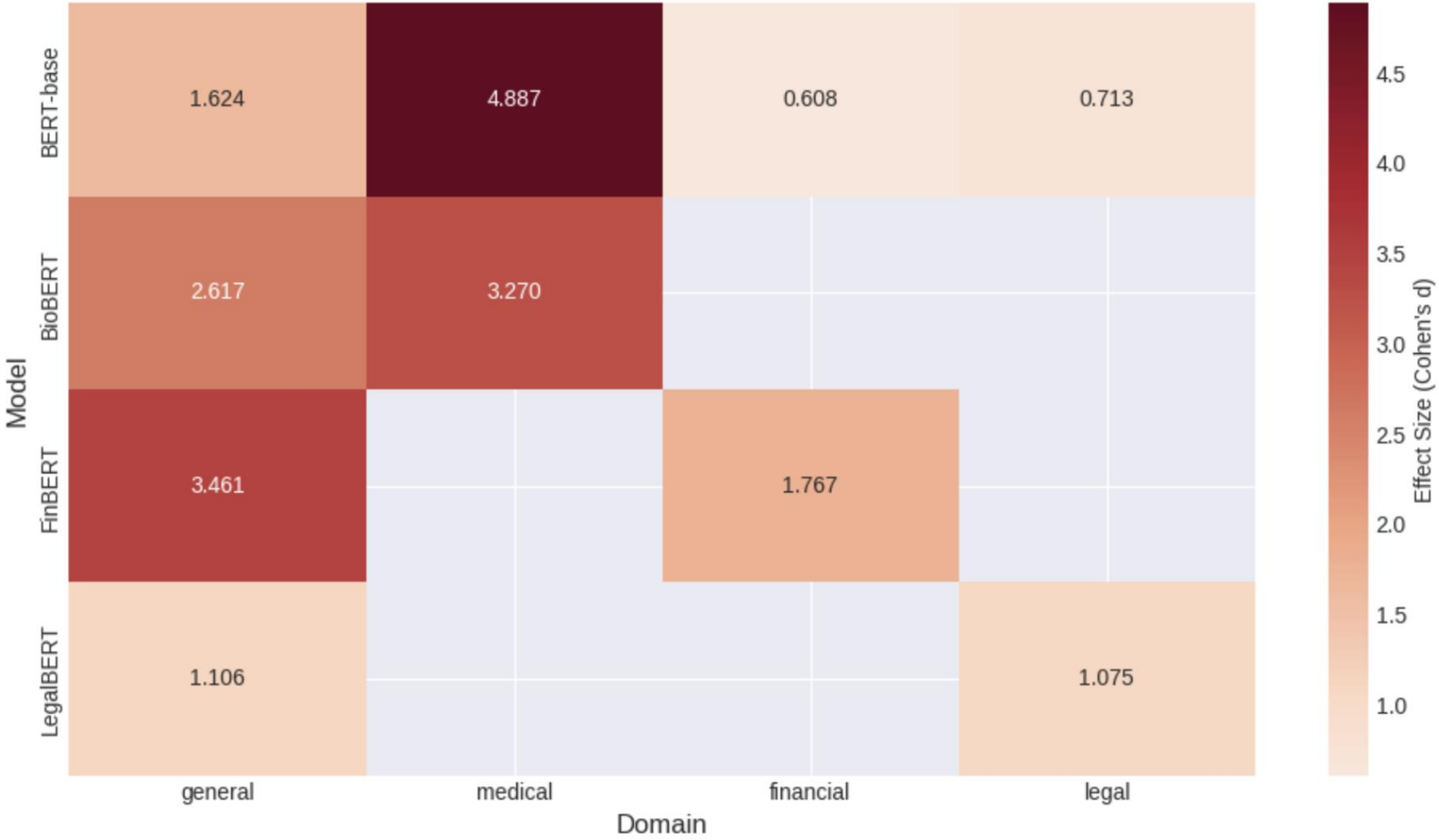
$$\text{Association} = (\text{Sim}_{\text{Male, HighStatus}} - \text{Sim}_{\text{Male, Supportive}}) - (\text{Sim}_{\text{Female, HighStatus}} - \text{Sim}_{\text{Female, Supportive}})$$

- *Association reveals if the word “man” is more closely associated with High-Status words than “woman" is*

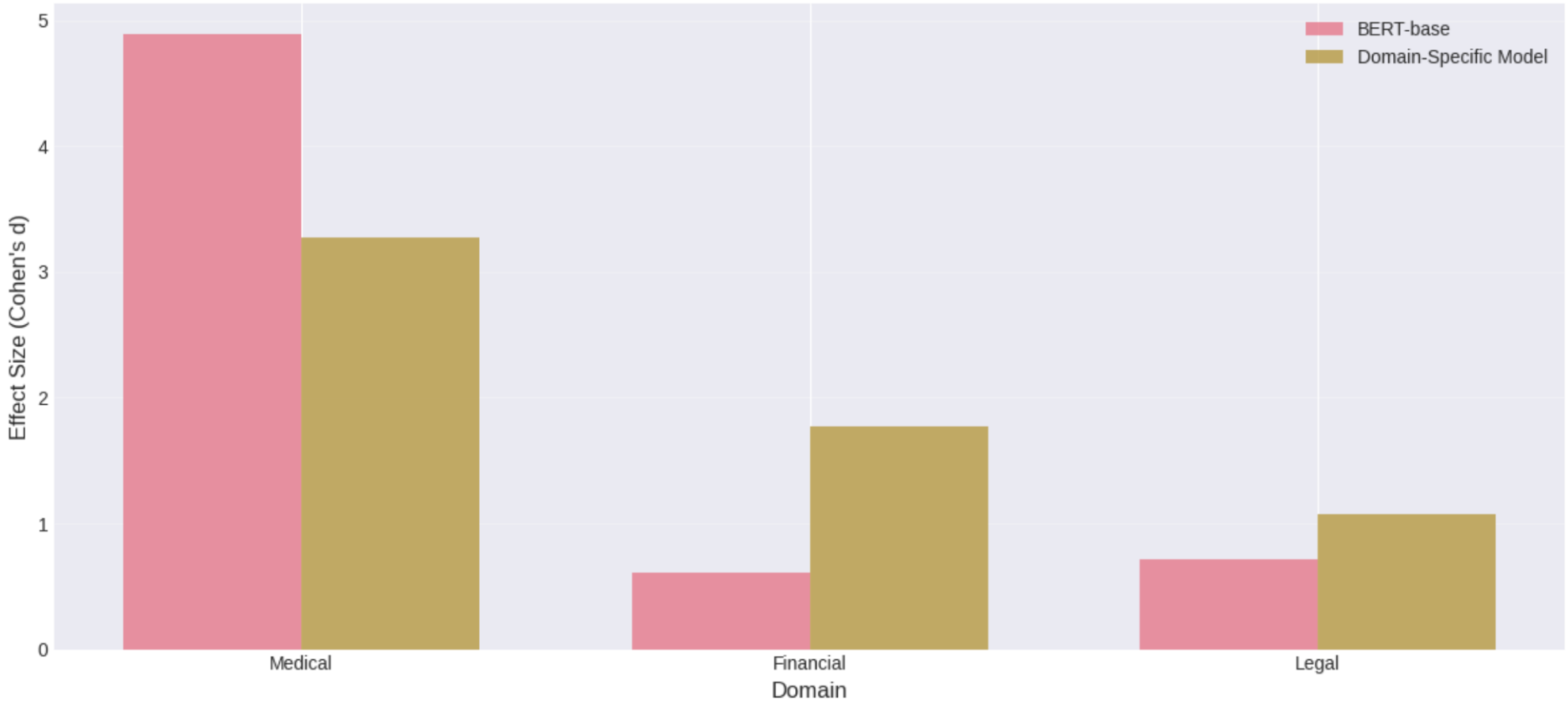
2. Calculate association for every Template (e.g. "The [TARGET] is a very professional [ATTRIBUTE].", "I met a [TARGET] who works as a [ATTRIBUTE].”) in accordance with Transformer nature of BERT

3. Calculate **Effect Size (Cohen’s d):**
   Mean Difference: The average bias across all sentences.
   Standard Deviation: how much the bias varies between sentences.
   C-WEAT Effect Size: mean/sd
   High Positiv Score: stronger association between **Men and High-Status** roles (and Women and Supportive roles) than the reverse

C-WEAT Effect Size



BERT-base vs Domain-Specific Models



Core finding

CrowS-Pairs ranking regarding Gender Bias:

1. FinBERT
2. LegalBERT
3. BioBERT
4. BERT-base

C-WEAT ranking on average effect size (per model, in every domain it was tested in)

1. LegalBERT
2. FinBERT
3. BERT-base
4. BioBERT

Key takewawy

Domain pretraining reshapes rather than uniformly amplifies bias

BioBERT retains strongest professional role stereotypes (concerning for healthcare deployment)

FinBERT and LegalBERT show promise: domain training can reduce specific stereotypes

Implication: Need domain-specific debiasing strategies, not one-size-fits-all approaches